

5 Questions to Ask Before You Start Writing Your Book

A clarity guide from Rachel Arterberry • Ghostwriter & Developmental Editor

1

Who is this book really for?

Not "anyone interested in leadership" or "busy professionals everywhere." A book that speaks to everyone lands with no one. Name a specific reader: their job title, their daily frustration, the question they Google at midnight. When you can describe that person clearly, you're ready.

2

What is the one thing I want my reader to do differently?

Every strong book creates a shift. It changes how someone thinks, decides, or acts. Before you write chapter one, finish this sentence: After reading my book, my reader will _____. If you can't complete it, your book doesn't have a destination yet. Find the destination first.

3

What do I know that my reader doesn't — and how did I learn it?

Your expertise isn't just what you know. It's the path you took to know it: the client who taught you something unexpected, the failure that reframed your approach, the moment a framework you'd used for years stopped working. That path is what makes your book yours. No one else has walked it.

4

Am I willing to take a position?

The safest book presents every side equally and commits to nothing. It's also the least useful. Your reader isn't hiring your book to be objective — they're reading it because they trust your judgment. A book without a clear point of view is a book without a reason to exist. Say what you believe.

5

Do I have the right support around this manuscript?

Writing a book is not a solo project. You need someone who challenges the structure of your thinking, not just the grammar of your sentences. A developmental editor. A ghostwriter who can hold your voice while shaping your ideas. Someone who knows what "ready" actually looks like.